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Hospital Staffing Shortages Draw Hundreds of Nurses and Healthcare Professionals to Rally at State Capitol on May 7

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More than 400 healthcare union members return to Sacramento during Nurses Week in a direct appeal to elected leaders: Fix education backlog and staffing issues that impact patient care.

Rally at California State Capitol: West Steps, 10th Street and Capitol Avenue, SacramentoTuesday, May 7, 2024; 11:30 a.m. - 12:30 p.m.Call to schedule onsite interviews with nurses attending rally.Photos and video of the rally will be available for media after the event at www.unacuhcp.org/backlog

SACRAMENTO, Calif., May 6, 2024 /PRNewswire/ -- Experts predict that more nurses will leave the bedside in the next 10 years and that other healthcare professionals may follow suit. (See Facts: www.unacuhcp.org/backlog). UNAC/UHCP members throughout California will return to Sacramento, urging solutions that will lead more students to remain in their communities for their healthcare careers, and empower them to enforce safe staffing in their hospitals.

Organized during Nurses Week, the rally highlights the urgent need for investment in nurse education and support for all healthcare professionals struggling with too many patients and insufficient staff to provide the safest care.

"Getting my nursing degree at my local community college was the path that allowed me to pursue my dream of becoming a nurse without going into debt," said Charmaine S. Morales, a registered nurse and president of UNAC/UHCP. "We cannot ignore the impact of the education backlog on hospital staffing and patient outcomes."

Morales added that current nurses and care providers feel their staffing complaints have fallen on deaf ears: "We need to improve how our state agencies handle short staffing. We cannot fix this crisis alone."

Union members will urge elected officials to prioritize the next generation of caregivers by passing legislation to expand advanced degree programs to community colleges and increase clinical placement opportunities for nursing students. The supply of nurses heavily relies on the state's higher education system, particularly California community college nursing programs, which train and supply a sizable proportion of California's nurses.

UNAC/UHCP members will visit their local representatives in Sacramento to discuss current proposals. We are asking elected officials to:

•Increase funding for nursing programs at community colleges in the state: California leaders can directly address nursing shortages with a $60 million budget proposal to expand nursing programs hosted by more than 70 community colleges in the state.

•Expand access to Bachelor of Science in Nursing degrees: By making advanced study programs available at the community college level, legislators can ensure students receive the necessary training to deliver high-quality, culturally competent care in their communities. (Senate Bill 895-Richard Roth)

•Expand clinical training for nursing students: Nursing students must complete clinical placement hours, but placements are not always available or accessible. With this legislation to increase hospital capacity to offer this training, more nursing students can graduate and enter the workforce. (Assembly Bill 1577-Evan Low and Senate Bill 1042-Richard Roth)

•Improve how the state provides information on safe staffing enforcement: When the California Department of Public Health (CDPH) finds a substantiated violation of licensed nurse-patient ratio rules and informs a general acute care hospital of the actions the agency plans to take, CDPH must also transmit the same information to the person who filed the claim of violation and their collective bargaining agent or representative, if any. The bill also mandates that if the department does not impose a fine, CDPH must send a statement explaining why to the person who filed the violation claim and any collective bargaining agent or representative. (Assembly Bill 2899-Jesse Gabriel)United Nurses Associations of California/Union of Health Care Professionals (UNAC/UHCP) represents more than 35,000 registered nurses and health care professionals in California and Hawaii, including optometrists; pharmacists; physical, occupational and speech therapists; case managers; nurse midwives; social workers; clinical lab scientists; physician assistants and nurse practitioners; hospital support and technical staff. UNAC/UHCP is affiliated with the National Union of Hospital and Health Care Employees and the American Federation of State, County and Municipal Employees, AFL-CIO.

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SOURCE United Nurses Associations of California / Union of Health Care Professionals

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